

Rebellion

Arjun had never cared much about birthdays. Forty refused to return the favour. The number had been sitting quietly in the corner of his mind for months. Not bothering him. Just waiting.

Thirty had arrived with excitement. There had been something heroic about thirty. It came carrying promises. Promotions. Adventures. Countries not yet visited. Relationships not yet ruined. Lives not yet chosen.

Forty arrived carrying questions.

That morning began like most mornings. At 5:27 a.m., Arjun's eyes opened before the alarm had a chance to announce itself. Years of habit had made the alarm mostly symbolic. The apartment was still dark. London slept behind rain-streaked glass.

For a moment he lay still. Forty. There it was again. Not fear. Not sadness. Just awareness. Like noticing a milestone while driving. You weren't stopping there. But you couldn't pretend you hadn't seen it.

The kettle clicked on. Meditation came first. It always did. Ten years earlier he would have laughed at the idea. Now he sat cross-legged in the small corner of the apartment he had unofficially assigned to silence. Meditation was supposed to help. Everybody agreed on that. Most books. Most podcasts. Most teachers. Clearer mind. More control. More peace. More understanding.

Arjun liked understanding. Understanding had solved most problems in his life. Not all of them. Most. He closed his eyes. Followed three breaths. Thought about work. Followed two more breaths. Thought about a conversation from the previous night. Followed one breath. Thought about Maya. Then gave up.

The coffee tasted exactly like yesterday's coffee. Strong. Predictable. Reliable. Three qualities Arjun increasingly

appreciated. Oats. Eggs. A quick scan of the news. The same black mug. The same spot at the dining table. The same routine. Twenty-three-year-old Arjun would have called it boring. Forty-year-old Arjun called it peaceful. At least most days.

His phone buzzed. Birthday messages. Friends. Family. Colleagues. People who somehow remembered these things. He scrolled absent-mindedly. A few jokes about age. Some warm wishes. One message stood out.

Welcome to the second half.

Arjun laughed. Then stopped. The second half. The phrase followed him longer than it should have. Because if this was the second half... what exactly had he done with the first?

That was the annoying thing about forty. It asked questions nobody had invited. Not dramatic questions. Inventory questions. Quiet questions. Questions that appeared while making coffee. Questions that arrived during walks. Questions that sat beside you in traffic. Questions that generally behaved like unwelcome relatives. Persistent. Difficult to remove.

He looked around the apartment. Organised. Minimal. Everything in its place. Much like the life he had spent years constructing. Career. Fitness. Responsibility. Discipline. Savings. Plans. Goals. The structure was respectable. Even admirable. At least from the outside.

So why did forty feel less like an arrival and more like an audit? Relationships. Jobs. Cities. Missed turns. Successful turns. People who stayed. People who left. Versions of himself he never became. The mind had started opening old drawers. One after another. Uninvited.

His phone buzzed again. Not a birthday message. A reply. The tattoo artist. A smile appeared before he could stop it. Months ago he had decided that forty deserved something permanent. Not because forty was special. Because he was tired of postponing things. His ex-wife had hated tattoos. Not aggressively. Just enough. One of those small preferences that quietly accumulates over years. One of those tiny compromises that never feel important individually. Until suddenly they do.

The plan had been simple. Get the tattoo during his next trip to India. Instead the message contained an unexpected surprise. The artist had opened a studio in London. Five kilometres from Arjun's apartment. He read the message twice. Then laughed. Of course. Life had a strange sense of timing.

Two hours later he was sitting in the studio. The walls were covered in possibilities. Years of postponed ideas suddenly surrounded him. Symbols. Animals. Quotes. Patterns. Entire stories waiting beneath skin. He had imagined this moment many times. Yet none of the designs felt right. Then his eyes stopped moving. Three words. Simple. Ancient. Unreasonably familiar.

Tat Tvam Asi.

He knew what it roughly meant. Not enough to explain it convincingly. Not enough to write a paper about it. Certainly not enough to permanently mark his body with it. Before thought. Before analysis. Before understanding. Something recognised it.

Walking home later that afternoon, the fresh tattoo stinging faintly beneath his sleeve, Arjun noticed something strange. He felt lighter. Not happier. Not transformed. Not wiser. Just lighter.

As though a tiny rebellion had finally succeeded. Against what exactly, he couldn't say. Only that something he had delayed for years had quietly become real. And for reasons he couldn't explain... that mattered.

What Was Trying to Emerge?

Arjun believed the tattoo mattered because of what it meant. Perhaps it mattered because, for once, he had not waited for permission. The pattern had not yet begun to look like a pattern.

